

grandfather Akbar and grandfather Jahangir, who engaged with non-Muslim religious figures, including Hindus and Christians, as Supriya Gandhi notes in *The Emperor Who Never Was: Dara Shukoh in Mughal India*. Aurangzeb also ordered the executions of Armenian Sufi Sarmad Kashani and the ninth Sikh guru, Tegh Bahadur.

Aurangzeb's legacy and career touch a raw nerve in Maharashtra. After Shivaji Maharaj made peace with the invading Mughal general Mirza Raja Jai Singh, he was invited to the Mughal court in Agra. Feeling insulted by his treatment, he walked out, was placed under house arrest, and famously staged a dramatic escape.

Following Shivaji's death in 1680, his elder son, Chhatrapati Sambhaji, ascended the throne but was captured and brutally executed in 1689. However, Maratha resistance persisted under Maharani Tarabai, wife of Shivaji's younger son Rajaram. Legendary generals Santaji Ghorpade and Dhanaji Jadhav put up a valiant fight.

Aurangzeb spent the last 27 years of his life in the Deccan, trying unsuccessfully to subdue the Marathas. He breathed his last on February 21, 1707, at Bhingar in Ahmednagar at the age of 89. His body was carried to Khultabad, near Aurangabad, renamed Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar in 2023. After his death, Sambhaji's son, Shahu, who had been imprisoned with his mother Yesubai and half-brother Madansinh since childhood, was released. Shahu had staved off attempts to convert him in captivity.

AURANGZEB SPENT THE LAST 27 YEARS OF HIS LIFE, TRYING UNSUCCESSFULLY TO SUBDUE THE MARATHAS

Historian Dulari Qureshi says Aurangzeb was buried in the courtyard of the tomb of Shaikh Zainuddin, in a simple enclosure he commissioned during his lifetime. Khultabad, known as the 'valley of saints,' was home to many Sufis, including Zar Zari Zar Baksh, a disciple of Nizamuddin Auliya of Delhi.

Aurangzeb's tomb was originally a wooden slab bearing a Persian inscription: 'No marble sheets should shield me from the sky as I lie there one with the earth.' Qureshi cites a legend that Aurangzeb decreed only Rs 14 and 12 annas—earned from stitching caps—be spent on his burial. He had also earned Rs 350 from Quranic inscriptions but refused to use it, believing he had made mistakes in copying.

In 1921, the Nizam of Hyderabad and Lord Curzon embellished the site with marble and a pierced marble screen. Yet, a patch of earth with a *sabja* plant remains, in keeping with his wish to rest under the open sky. ■

people were dead, several more injured, and the streets of Sambhal were locked down under Section 144. Internet services were suspended, schools closed and the district administration moved swiftly to prevent further escalation. CM Adityanath said the police action was in response to "provocative speeches" delivered after Friday prayers. The Opposition accused the BJP government of deliberately stoking tensions to polarise voters. Within days, the case reached the Supreme Court. The Shahi Jama Masjid Committee filed an urgent plea challenging the validity of the survey, arguing that it violated the Places of Worship Act. On November 29, the apex court stayed proceedings in the Sambhal trial court (which had mandated the surveys), ordered the survey report to be sealed and emphasised the need for "peace and harmony".

In this unsettled, already highly polarised environment, a fresh wave of controversy washed over Sambhal in March, when the state administration banned the annual Neja Mela, a festival traditionally held after Holi in honour of Syed Salar Masud Ghazi. The local tradition celebrating Ghazi Miyan as a warrior saint and martyr dates back to the 12th century but a later 17th century legend depicts him as a military commander of Mahmud of Ghazni, in campaigns across northern India, including the plundering of the Somnath temple in 1025 CE. The Neja Mela, observed by a section of the Muslim community, involves raising a ceremonial flag (Neja) and offering prayers to commemorate Ghazi.